



Koutoubia Mosque

A medieval mosque whose towering minaret dominates the skyline of the Moroccan city of Marrakech

The Koutoubia Mosque was built in the 12th century as an expression of the religious fervor of Berber tribesmen inspired by a radical version of Islam. Known as Almohads, these fierce but pious warriors swept down from the Atlas mountains to conquer all of northern Africa from Morocco to Egypt, as well as the Muslim areas of southern Spain.

Almohad leader Abd al-Mu'min ordered the first Koutoubia Mosque to be built as soon as he took possession of Marrakech in 1147. Unfortunately, a defect was discovered in the building—its *mihrab*, supposed to point the praying faithful toward Mecca, was slightly out of geographical alignment. So even before the first mosque was finished, work began on a second mosque alongside it, identical in every way except for its orientation. The first mosque was allowed to decay, the second being the one that stands today.

Mosque and medina

Completed during the reign of Almohad Caliph Yakub al-Mansur (r.1184–1199), the current mosque stands close to the narrow streets of the medina, Marrakech's atmospheric old town, and the famous Jemaa el-Fna square with its snake charmers and acrobats. The minaret is 230 ft (70 m) tall, made chiefly of pink-red sandstone, decorated with strips of colorful ceramic tiling and elaborately patterned window surrounds. The mosque's prayer hall contains fine examples of Moroccan craftwork, but it is not accessible to non-Muslims.

The name **Koutoubia Mosque** means "booksellers' mosque," for a trade much practiced nearby

